both within scenes he photographs and in the pages of his photobooks, adding context and descriptions to augment this approach.

Among the first professional projects he started after returning home to Brooklyn in 1954 was a series of photographs of Hassidic Jews who had survived the concentration camps and now lived in his old neighborhood. According to Ewing, Freed was drawn to them "not because he was one of them … but because he *might* have been one of them had history dealt his Russian family another hand."[31] The resulting images included Freed separated from his subjects through glass doors and windows and behind hats covering their faces, as they recognized the photographer with direct eye contact. (These were among the photographs he first showed to Magnum staffer Bondi and Museum of Modern Art curator Edward Steichen.) During this time, he began photographing Italian American and African American subjects as well, documenting schoolhouses and religious functions as well as street parades and other scenes of convergence. These early images attest to Freed's interest in framing division within social spaces of near-proximity and alienation, especially around matters of racial and ethnic identity.

Freed's move back to Europe in 1956 included his forays into freelance photography and his first substantive, book-length projects. The first of these, *Joden van Amsterdam* (1958), arrived in his mailbox on his wedding day to Brigitte.[32] According to Wim van Sinderen, Freed and his collaborator Dutch journalist Max Snijders "succeeded in finding a good balance between the shame and guilt of the Dutch and resignation and reticence of the Jewish community." This work marked a point of departure Freed would return to: locating Jewish communities against the backdrop of a European country that had spurned and targeted them during the Holocaust. After the publication of *Joden van Amsterdam*, Freed's focus on postwar European Jewry shifted to Germany and to his later *Deutsche Juden heute* book. As van Sinderen adds, "*Deutsche Juden heute* did not come about easily. … Very few [Jews] were prepared to expose themselves to the camera."[33] Freed did build trust with his subjects, photographing communal and ritualistic spaces, but he also sensed his own fraught position—as an American Jewish photographer working among a population that was hesitant to be photographed following the war.

The result, as evidenced in the images that would later comprise *Deutsche Juden heute*, taken primarily in 1961–62, informed his evolving and roving approach. As a photographer Freed wrestled with the issue of